

Illustration by **NILANJAN DAS**

cupboards are filled with horrific skeletons from communal orgies?

This is not to undermine the potential threat that communal elements pose to India's national fabric. We paid a heavy price for it at the time of Independence, the Amrit Mahotsav of which is being celebrated now. These elements, be it Muslim or Hindu, do not and should not represent our respective mainstream communities. To merely shrug off responsibility for their actions also amounts to being communal apologists. There is a need to frame a civil society response to it.

Social media is partly to blame. It is democratic not only in nature and spirit but also in noise and chaos. Perceived injustices as portrayed on Twitter or Facebook impact sensible people too. But the problem is that different stories and images circulate among different recipient groups, making each believe that their religion is under attack from the other. While the image of an attack on a Hindu procession gets wider traction among Hindu user groups, similar provocative images of acts against a mosque or a Muslim group make their way to Muslim user groups. Hence the important lesson that the social media narrative needs to be viewed with greater equanimity and objectivity and that it allows the law and order establishment to take necessary action against the culprits.

THE TALK OF POLARISATION MAY BE PREMATURE. INDIAN SOCIAL LEADERS NEED TO STAND UP TO THE FORCES OF HATRED AND VIOLENCE

These incidents are not all fictitious either. Every hate speech will have a fallout; every rape threat actually translates into a real incident. Hence the social leadership should immediately come forward, condemn and explicitly state that such words and acts have no place in a civilised discourse.

Post-Independence India witnessed the pampering of minority communal politics for vote bank considerations by the same parties that are preaching morals today. Communalism begets communalism. That brand of politics of appeasement has ended for good in the country, so the Opposition is calling the new order majoritarian politics. The minority leadership should reconcile to their new status and the end of such minority-majority distinctions. Learning to live in harmony with the rest of our mainstream national society should be viewed as an important obligation.

It is also important that the Muslim leadership come out of the Wahhabist hardline interpretations of Islam that seek to pit Muslim against non-Muslim and promote separatism and exclusivity. The return of debates like 'hijab' and 'niqab' is symptomatic of this as also the rise of violent, ultra-radical outfits like the Popular Front of India (PFI). A more inclusive and humanitarian Islam on the lines of the one promoted by organisations like Nahdlatul Ulama, a 90 million-strong Islamic organisation in Indonesia under the dynamic leadership of its chairman Yahya Cholil Staquf aka Pak Yahya, must be the way forward for them.

The reaction of sections of Hindus, including some wearing saffron robes, is also utterly un-Hindu. Violent language and talk of annihilation of an entire community smack of their attempt at semitisation of Hinduism. It is pertinent to note that mainstream Hindu organisations like the RSS have distanced themselves and disapproved of such rants.

Talk of polarisation may be premature but the Indian social leadership needs to stand up to the forces of hatred and violence by invoking peace, inclusivity and a nation-first narrative. India's narrative of the decade should be "it's the economy, stupid!" The onus lies on all of us. ■